

TSMC going 28nm

TSMC claims that their 40nm fabrication is over its teething troubles and are preparing a 28nm fab

Ion2 coming finally?

NVIDIA's Ion2 based netbooks rumoured to launch in Q2 2010

Netbook test

special, but there's something about the overall effect that is nice. MSI follows the glossy lid with a smooth black finish inside which as a whole, other than its thickness the U130 isn't too bad looking. As mentioned, the bezel will not appeal to our slim-everything loving generation. Under the lid, the left/right click is a single strip and while

The control key on the left is not the corner key – an ergonomic goof up many netbook vendors are guilty of, and one that there is just no getting used to. The speakers exhibit a complete lack of bass; in fact LF sounds are missed for the most part. The webcam despite its impressive rating of 1.3 megapixels is pretty ordinary, but



MSI U130

small, it is easy to use, though the button feels unnecessarily clicky. The choice of material on the trackpad is good for accurate tracking and there is a great balance between grip and slip; the mouse buttons are a bit hard to press. The keys are slightly smaller than what is considered comfortable. Key spacing is a little on the skimpy side. To be honest notebook, users will struggle to adjust. Unfortunately it seems a larger surface area on the top of each key would have helped, instead MSI chose to have keys with sloping sides – meaning a lot of potential contact area between your fingerpads and the keypad is missing. Towards the right side on the bottom edge of the palmrest is a group of LED indicators. There are no shortcut keys and the power button feels clicky, thankfully it's black – no garish chrome here.

better than the other 0.3-megapixel units out there. Just make sure you use it in well-illuminated surroundings.

Finding Windows 7 Starter Edition was a nice surprise, as was the performance in the Wi-Fi test. DisplayMate trashes the screen. At 1024 x 600 pixels, a product highlight it is not. Brightness levels are okay, but the colour and contrast is very minimal. The resolution might be a problem for hardcore internet-junkies. Note that the U130 is based on the new Pinetrail platform and this makes it a frugal performer when it comes to power con-

sumption, even though MSI cheated a bit by sending us a 6 cell battery. The U130 is generally available with a 3 cell; the 6 cell being optional. We were able to get over five and half hours – not bad at all. Shockingly, this tiny netbook chalked up the highest 3D Mark scores, including the CPU score, a testament to its new innards. Incidentally, the model we received did not have support for a SIM, although this is optional.

Rs. 23,000 may seem like a lot to pay for a netbook, but such is always the case with new hardware. Expect a price drop within the next five months as competing models also incorporate Pinetrail. However, MSI can do a lot more in the looks department; for when blowing close to 23,000 rupees on a netbook, we expect a bit of glitz.

Gateway LT2002I

Entry to mediocrity

Gateway has tried to impart the LT2002I with a slightly different look. The outcome is

a netbook much slimmer than the U130 and the design sees the battery pack protruding from the rear, which is better when using the device, but may not be better when carting it around. The lid is glossy and has a thin grey-silver bezel running around it that when viewed from the top disappears into the front of the lid. This insert provides a welcome relief from the body that is otherwise entirely plain. Build quality is good and the materials used seem good. The lid clips have a garish chrome trim that is a glaring contrast to the suaveness of the overall design, but it only looks garish from the inside. The bezel is a little too wide, especially on the top – the only spoiler for the otherwise good design. As mentioned, the battery pack protrudes out the rear but doesn't add much to the height of the device.

Open her up and the Bluetooth button sitting amid the status indicator LEDs is welcome, though a Wi-Fi button may have been more useful.



Gateway LT2002I

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